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Su Shih's "Notes" as a Historical and Literary Source

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THE "note" is a genre of Chinese writing that only began to survive in any quantity in the Northern Sung dynasty. It is most readily distinguished from its older cousin, the letter (*shu* 書), by its brevity. The note, which is variously called *shu-chien* 書簡, *ch'ih-tu* 尺牘, or *tao-pi* 刀筆, is often no more than a few sentences long. But the note's brevity is just one consequence of its unique function and nature. The note is a practical kind of missive usually sent to close friends or family. Its subjects tend to be mundane and its tone straightforward. It is written in a language that must be called Literary Chinese, but the style is as plain and unliterary as that language could ever be.

The *shu* or letter had a long history extending back at least to the Former Han dynasty. As a polished and elegant form of expression covering a wide variety of intellectual subjects, it was naturally included in individual literary collections and anthologies. The note, being unpolished, was generally not considered fit for inclusion in literary compilations. But in the Northern Sung, apparently for the first time in Chinese history, collections of certain individuals' notes began to circulate separately from their literary writings.¹ Later

¹ See the Ssu-k'ü editors' comments on the collection of Huang T'ing-chien's notes, *Ho-yin Ssu-k'ü ch'üan-shu tsung-mu t'i-yao chi Ssu-k'ü wei-shou shu-mu chün-hui shu-mu* 合印四庫全書總目提要及四庫未收書目禁燬書目 (Taipei: Commercial Press, 1978), 174.3745-46.

these notes would sometimes be included in an individual's "complete works." In certain cases, then, we find both forms of correspondence preserved in a writer's works. But typically they are rigorously distinguished by the Sung editors and referred to by different names.

No doubt the interest that Sung dynasty scholars took in historiography, of the recent as well as the distant past, partly accounts for the survival of these notes. Their preservation also must owe much to the spread of book printing during the eleventh and twelfth centuries. Another factor is the great appreciation Sung literati had of calligraphy. Two of the Northern Sung's most voluminous collections of notes are by two of the period's finest calligraphers, Su Shih and Huang T'ing-chien. Had there not been persons who prized even the most brief and seemingly insignificant note for its appealing calligraphy, it is unlikely that so many notes would have survived for later editors to collect and reprint.² The numbers involved are impressive and dwarf those of the lengthier letter: fifteen hundred of Su Shih's notes and twelve hundred of Huang T'ing-chien's are extant (compared with only forty-one and thirty-five letters by the two men, respectively).³

One of my purposes here is to call attention to the note as a historical source. It should become evident in the examples below that Su Shih's notes often provide insight into levels of mundane life that are seldom if ever illuminated in his more formal writings. This potential of the notes has generally gone untapped, both by Sung historians and by specialists in Su Shih. To be sure, pre-modern commentators utilized these notes; they pored over them to elucidate the factual details of Su's life. But the only modern scholar to use Su's notes extensively is Chikusa Masaaki 竺沙雅章, whose study of land ownership among Northern Sung literati is based upon the frequent references contained in the notes to the price and purchase of land.⁴

² This point is made by Murakami Tetsumi 村上哲見 in his study of the textual history of Su Shih's letters, "So Tōba shokan no denrai to Tōbashū shohon no keifu ni tsuite" 蘇東坡書簡の傳來と東坡集諸本の系譜について, *Chūgoku bungaku hō* 27 (1977): 61-64.

³ Huang's notes are reproduced in *Fen-hsin ko ts'ung-shu* 紛欣閣叢書, ed. Chou Ju-hsin 周如心 (1827).

⁴ Chikusa Masaaki, "Hoku Sō shidaifu no shikyo to baiden—omo ni Tōba sekitoku o shiryō to site" 北宋士大夫の徒居と買田—主に東坡尺牘を資料として, *Shilin* 54.2 (1971): 28-52.

There has also been a minor but persistent tradition of the literary appreciation of Su Shih's notes. While this appreciation can be traced back to Su's own day, Sung scholars seem to value the notes primarily for their calligraphy.⁵ They eagerly collected original manuscripts or rubbings of the notes, just as they collected anything written in Su's hand. The appreciation of the notes solely for their literary qualities is apparently a later development, one contemporary with Ming and Ch'ing dynasty interest in various short forms of literary prose (*hsiao p'in wen* 小品文), which came to include notes and letters. The late Ming scholar Chiao Hung 焦竑 compiled a work that consisted solely of Su Shih's notes and his songs (*tz'u* 詞), and he gave it the title *Venerable Su's Two Marvels* 蘇長公二妙集.⁶ The implicit claim of such a work is that it is precisely those writings conventionally considered Su's most inconsequential and unliterary that best exemplify his genius and constitute his greatest achievement. This appraisal of Su's notes, which finds beauty in their unpretentiousness and admires the unstudied elegance with which they address everyday matters, has been reiterated in modern times by the essayist Chou Tso-jen 周作人 and the scholar Lung Mu-hsun 龍沐勛.⁷

The text I have used is from the new collated and punctuated edition of Su's complete prose edited by K'ung Fan-li 孔凡禮,⁸ where the notes account for nearly one-fifth of the six-volume total. The textual history of Su's notes is complex and, in its crucial early stages, obscure. We know that Su's notes circulated separately from

⁵ See the colophons on manuscripts of Su's notes by Huang T'ing-chien, Lu Yu, and Chu Hsi: "Pa wei-tso Tung-p'o shu-chien," *Yü-chang Huang hsien-sheng wen-chi* 豫章黃先生文集 (SPTK ed.), 29.9b-10a, "Pa P'o Ku t'ieh," *Fang-weng t'i-pa* 放翁題跋 (*Ts'ung-shu chi-ch'eng* ed.), 6.48, and "Pa Chou ssu-ling so-ts'ang Tung-p'o t'ieh," *Hui-an t'i-pa* 晦菴題跋 (*Ts'ung-shu chi-ch'eng* ed.), 3.73. These colophons are all quoted by Murakami Tetsumi, pp. 60-62.

⁶ The work was compiled by Chiao Hung in 1618 and printed by Hsu Hsiang-yun 徐象樞 in 1621. See Mei Lan 美蘭, "Tung-p'o tz'u pan-pen chien-chieh" 東坡詞版本簡介, *Tung-p'o tz'u lun-ts'ung* 東坡詞論叢 (*Su Shih yen-chiu lun-wen chi* 蘇軾研究論文集, no. 1; Ch'eng-tu: Ssu-ch'uan jen-min ch'u-pan she, 1982), pp. 271-72; and Liu Shang-jung 劉尚榮, *Su Shih chu-tso pan-pen lun-ts'ung* 蘇軾著作版本論叢 (Ch'eng-tu: Pa-shu shu-she, 1988), pp. 138-140.

⁷ Lung Mu-hsun, *Su Huang ch'ih-tu hsuan* 蘇黃尺牘選 (n.p., Commercial Press, 1939), pp. i-xi. Chou Tso-jen's praise of the literary qualities of Su's (and Huang T'ing-chien's) notes is found in his "Ch'ung-yin Yuan Chung-lang ch'üan-chi," *K'u-ch'a sui-pi* 苦茶隨筆 (Ch'ang-sha: Yueh-lu shu-she, 1987 rpt.), p. 59 (quoted by Lung Mu-hsun, p. ii).

⁸ K'ung Fan-li, *Su Shih wen-chi* 蘇軾文集, 6 vols. (Peking: Chung-hua shu-chü, 1986). Hereafter cited as *Wen-chi*.

his other works at least as early as the Yuan dynasty.⁹ We also know that the Sung dynasty itself had witnessed the publication of no fewer than two dozen collections of Su's writings, including a *wai-chi* 外集 that contained notes. K'ung Fan-li's edition is based on Mao Wei's 茅維 *Su Wen-chung kung ch'üan-chi* 蘇文忠公全集, in seventy-five *chüan*, published early in the seventeenth century. Mao's edition contains 1283 of Su's notes and is evidently based on a collection of notes that circulated widely towards the end of the Ming (for other Ming works reproduce Su's notes in the same order), but we do not know whether the source was the Sung *wai-chi* or a separate collection of notes. This recension of Su's notes is, in any case, much larger than that found in the popular "seven collections" 七集 edition of Su's works published in 1468, which is the ancestor of many editions of Su's works that were widely used through Ch'ing times and even today.¹⁰ Only 796 of Su's notes are found in the "seven collections" edition (in the *hsu-chi* 續集 section). Moreover, there is no apparent order to their arrangement. In Mao Wei's edition, by contrast, the notes are conveniently arranged: all the pieces addressed to one person appear side by side, and within each set the pieces are arranged chronologically (as best they can be). Aside from collating and reprinting Mao Wei's collection of notes, K'ung Fan-li has also recovered 218 more of Su's notes from dozens of ancillary sources. These he presents in his section of Su's "lost works."

The troubling problem of authenticity should be mentioned in this connection, even though there is essentially no solution to it. With a writer as famous as Su Shih, and a form so short and private, forgery must have been for some scholars an irresistible

⁹ A fragmentary Yuan edition, entitled *Tung-p'o hsien-sheng han-mo ch'ih-tu* 東坡先生翰墨尺牘, is held in the Peking Municipal Library. This and other information on the textual history of Su's notes comes from: K'ung Fan-li's preface to *Wen-chi* 1:ii-iii; Liu Shang-jung, pp. 112-18, 122-23, and 153-54; and the earlier study by Murakami Tetsumi, cited above.

¹⁰ Including those found in *Ssu-k'u ch'üan-shu*, *Ssu-pu pei-yao*, and the Commercial Press's *Basic Sinological Series*. For Su Shih's prose, K'ung Fan-li's new edition should supersede these other versions (as other editions of Su's poetry have replaced the "seven collections" poetry). It should be noted that the standard English language bibliographical account of Su's "complete works" describes this "seven collections" recension, now of little use. See *A Sung Bibliography*, ed. by Yves Hervouet (Hong Kong: The Chinese University Press, 1978), pp. 396-98.

temptation. No doubt there are spurious notes among the fifteen hundred in K'ung Fan-li's compilation. Furthermore, it is unrealistic to think we may be able to detect the fraudulent notes on the basis of their content or style. Huang T'ing-chien admits to having difficulty deciding about a particular note attributed to Su.¹¹ If Huang, who was Su's intimate friend and also a connoisseur of calligraphy, was hard-pressed to tell, we should not expect to be able to ourselves. Nevertheless, the value of the notes for us today lies in the distinctive picture they collectively evoke of daily life among the lettered class. It is this texture of detail, whose specifics are reiterated in different notes, rather than revelations unique to one note, that is of primary importance. We might also find consolation in the thought that this matter of authenticity, as bothersome as it is, is far less problematic for us than it was for the Sung scholars. They collected manuscripts; thus for them a forgery might be either a spurious text or spurious calligraphy (i.e., an authentic text that was copied over by an unscrupulous calligrapher). This latter possibility does not concern us here.

A SURVEY OF SUBJECTS

Su Shih's notes divide themselves naturally into two broad categories distinguished by subject: those that bear on Su's involvement with the bureaucracy, and those that concern his private life. Numerically, the latter dominate (and of course there are notes in which both subjects figure), but the former hold just as much interest, especially for the institutional or cultural historian. What we glimpse in the bureaucracy notes is all the behind-the-scenes maneuvering Su Shih engaged in to try to influence bureaucratic decisions (e.g., who will get what appointment, what policy will be implemented). It is unthinkable that Su and his peers were not constantly involved in such attempts to exert influence through private channels, appealing often to considerations that could not be mentioned in public documents, but of course the mass of formal bureaucratic writings these men produced seldom gives us any glimpse of this

¹¹ See the colophon by Huang cited in n. 5. Chu Hsi admits to having the same difficulty with another manuscript attributed to Su (see n. 5).

aspect of their activities. Some examples of this sort of note are given below.

A short chronology of Su's life is provided first for reference:

- 1037 Born in Mei-shan (Szechwan)
- 1057 *Chin-shih* degree
- 1057-68 Mourning periods for parents and first assignments
- 1069-70 Protests Wang An-shih's New Policies
- 1071-73 Vice-governor of Hang-chou
- 1074-76 Governor of Mi-chou
- 1077-79 Governor of Hsu-chou
- 1079 Arrest and trial for slandering the government
- 1080-84 Exile in Huang-chou
- 1085 Governor of Teng-chou
- 1086-88 Recall to Court as Han-lin Academician
- 1089-91 Governor of Hang-chou
- 1091-93 Recall to court
- 1094-96 Exile in Hui-chou
- 1097-99 Exile in Hai-nan Island
- 1100 Pardon and return to mainland
- 1101 Died in Ch'ang-chou

Few of Su's notes are internally dated, but most can be assigned to a specific period of his life (e.g., Huang-chou, Hui-chou), based on their content and the identity of the addressee. This way of dating the notes—by place and thus period—can be traced back to Ming editions, and probably goes back earlier still. I provide this information (following K'ung Fan-li) at the head of each translation.

(To Fan Tzu-feng, from Hsu-chou:) Have you received the letter I recently sent with that messenger? Is your family well, and are affairs at your bureau gradually getting settled? Fortunately, we at this end are all in good health. The drought continues here unabated, and both refugees and bandits have appeared in numbers. The breach in the Yellow River dike has not yet been repaired, and the floodwaters rise every day. All this chaos and suffering—when will it end?

Regarding my recent request to be assigned to Ssu-ming, I wonder whether it will be granted? If not, I shall be happy with any other small prefecture in the Chiang-huai region and will not presume to be choosy. Tzu-feng, could you put in a word for me with the gentlemen there? Please consider it. If you could send some answer with this man when he returns I would feel myself extremely fortunate.

There is no telling when I shall meet you next. By all means take care of yourself as the seasons require. (50.1451, no. 3)¹²

Fan Tzu-feng (Pai-lu) was serving in the capital in the Bureau of Policy Criticism.

(To Ts'ai Ching-fan, from Huang-chou:) The other day I personally saw Hsu Shao-chang die a painful death and a few days later I heard that Tung Yi-fu had also been transformed. Life is so fragile and quick, is it really not just the space of a breath? It makes one even more impatient with the ways of the world. Shao-chang himself had just traveled hurriedly home to take care of the burial of his own parents. On the day he died his purse was empty and there was nearly nothing with which to bury him. His younger brother, the magistrate of Ma-ch'eng, is even poorer and says that he has not an inch of land to return to. I know you will be saddened to hear this, and I imagine the Court will also feel pity for him. With as much weight as your views carry, could you put in a word for him? I beg your indulgence for speaking out of place this way. (55.1663, no. 7)

Ts'ai Ching-fan (Ch'eng-hsi) was an assistant fiscal intendant of Huai-nan when this was written, in 1084. Hsu Shao-chang (An-shih) had died at the age of twenty-six.

(To Lü Yuan-chün, while in the Han-lin Academy:) Recently, I learned that you have been promoted. Although this might be of some comfort to other people, what you really deserve is a position at the Court. How, then, does this promotion call for congratulations? Here, gossip and accusations are everywhere, and recently even worse than before. Officials eye each other suspiciously and seek nothing more than to avoid incrimination. What time do they possibly have to formulate policies for the Court or provinces? As for what you told me, it saddens me. Before long, I will explain my feelings fully to you—as soon as Chi-ch'ang's messenger departs. (59.1799, no. 2)

Lü Yuan-chün (Lü T'ao), Su's close friend and supporter, was to hold Court posts later in the Yuan-yu period. Chi-ch'ang (Ch'en Tsao) was one of Su's Huang-chou friends.

(To Chang Tzu-p'ing, from Hang-chou:) I have few obligations just now and decided to try to get in touch with you. In Ching-k'ou there is a prefectural degree holder, Ch'en Fu-chih, whose learning and conduct are superior and whose poetry and prose are also extraordinary. He is extremely close to Wang Ching-kung (An-shih), but when Ching-kung was in power, Fu-chih had nothing to do with him. After Ching-kung retired to Chin-ling, Fu-chih matched poems together with him day after day. Fu-chih is a solitary man and has few friends. He did not marry and did not enter government service. He is like the ancients and acts in any way he sees fit. Nevertheless, he is extremely poor and has inadequate means to support himself. I thought that perhaps if your prefecture does not yet have an education

¹² References are to K'ung Fan-li's edition, cited above.

official you might employ this man. How would that be? Please let me know what you think. How much is the monthly salary? If you think it would be adequate, then you might send a letter asking him. If you already have someone else or if there are other impediments, then let's just drop the matter. Pitying him for being so alone, proud, and impoverished, I have brashly spoken out here on his behalf. Forgive me, forgive me. (55.1641, no. 6)

Chang Tzu-p'ing (Chang Heng) held several provincial governorships during the period this note dates from, including posts at Su-chou, Yang-chou, and Ying-chou. There is no indication that Chang acted on Su's suggestion.

(To a certain Hsuan-te, after leaving Hang-chou:) I have received the parting gift of five *liang* of gold and 150 *liang* of silver from your messenger. Formerly, when I was transferred from Huang to Ju, I also received a generous offering from you. At that time I was nearly a cold starved corpse, but still I declined it. Today I have been promoted as a minister close to His Majesty and have more than enough wine. Not being all dried up, how could I accept? Nevertheless, I was afraid that for me to go against your kindness repeatedly was not to behave as a friend, and so I have sent the gift on to Hang-chou and, with your good intentions in mind, have turned it over to a hospital there. It is a hospital I founded while in Hang-chou and has by now become well established. Every year it receives a thousand *hu* of tax rice, and it has saved innumerable lives. Those in charge will use your gift to buy land to care for the impoverished among Heaven's people. I know this is your own family tradition, and so I have acted on its example. It will add to your own good fortune and longevity, and it will be to my own honor as well. I am sure your will not find it amiss. As for my gratitude to you, it is now no less than if I had accepted the gift into my own purse. ("Yi-wen hui-pien," 2.2447)

(To Wang Ting-kuo, from Ying-chou:) I was very eager to rejoin Le-ch'üan, as we had agreed, and intended to request reassignment to the southern capital. But Tzu-k'ai wrote warning me strongly that I must not. Moreover, my niece also wrote saying that her parents-in-law are now very comfortable there and the assignment must not be taken away from them. . . . (52.1527, no. 31)

Tzu-k'ai is Tseng Chao, the younger brother of Tseng Kung. The niece mentioned here, who was Tzu-k'ai's daughter-in-law, was probably the daughter of Su Shih's younger brother, Su Ch'e.¹³ The elderly Le-ch'üan (Chang Fang-p'ing) was living in retirement in the southern capital.

One reads such notes with difficulty, owing to the disadvantage of not knowing, in most cases, the precise circumstances under which they were written. We try to reconstruct a context, based on the contents of the note and what we may know about the addressee, but

¹³ We know that one of Su Ch'e's daughters married a man with the surname Tseng, see Tseng Tsao-chuang, 曾棗莊 "Su Ch'e nien-p'u" 蘇轍年譜, *Ssu-ch'uan ta-hsueh hsueh-pan ts'ung-k'an* 21 (1983): 25.

often our success is only partial. The fact is, many of Su's notes refer to people or events that are unrecorded elsewhere. Moreover, in the great majority of cases we have only Su Shih's note, not the other person's response or initial message. We reach in these notes levels of the commonplace, within elite culture, that engender historical obscurity. But it is precisely the mundane, if obscure, nature of the notes that makes them interesting.

Notes such as those above suggest how widespread and important personal appeals and private influence were in the operation of the Sung bureaucracy. In two of the notes Su Shih asks that friends be given a post or promotion. In requesting these favors, Su Shih stresses both the worthiness and the impoverishment of the friends. In another two notes Su Shih refers to his own preferences for reassignment. We know that Su did not receive the assignment to Ssu-ming he desired (see the first note above). However, he was reassigned to another prefecture in the Chiang-huai region, Huchou, just as he requested. It is plausible that this note, and Policy Critic Fan's subsequent efforts on Su's behalf, helped to bring about that assignment. Or did Su Shih send many such notes to various powerful officials, repeating the requests he makes to Fan Tzu-feng? But no other note on this matter survives in Su's voluminous collection. As for Su's desire years later in his career to be given a post at the southern capital (Shang-ch'iu, Honan), it appears from the last note translated above that he was dissuaded by the sitting governor there, Tseng Chao, who did not want to be replaced and relocated.¹⁴ Special credit for persuading Su to desist goes to Tseng Chao's daughter-in-law, who happened to be Su Shih's niece. Her filial plea is what Su represents as the deciding factor in his decision to abandon his plan of rejoining his old friend, Chang Fang-p'ing, in the southern capital.

One would like to know more about the mysterious Hsuan-te (the addressee of the fifth note above), who kept sending Su Shih unsolicited gifts of silver and gold. Perhaps he is Yueh Hsuan-te, a man mentioned in another note,¹⁵ but that is just a name and we have no information to attach to it. Whatever Hsuan-te's motives

¹⁴ That Tseng Chao was indeed governor of the prefecture, also called Ying-t'ien fu, in 1091 is confirmed in *Sung shih* (Peking: Chung-hua shu-ch'ü ed., 1977), 319.10394.

¹⁵ "Yü Yang Yuan-su," no. 9, *Wen-chi* 55.1653.

were, Su Shih obviously felt that he would have compromised himself if he had accepted the gifts. The first time, Su must have returned the money straightaway. Faced now with a second offering, Su hits upon the idea of making the impropriety serve a charitable cause. Hsuan-te is not going to get his money back this time, yet it will not end up in Su Shih's pocket. We know that one of Su Shih's achievements while governor of Hang-chou from 1089 to 1091 was to establish some sort of hospital or infirmary there. Su Shih never comments on the institution himself (except in this note), but other sources report that he raised two thousand strings of cash from private donors, installed a Buddhist monk to run the institution, and arranged to have it supported by an annual allotment of government grain.¹⁶ Thanks to Hsuan-te, this hospital now received an additional contribution.

Naturally, the various requests and attempts to exert influence that we find in these notes are couched in suitably polite and self-deprecating language. However, despite the gentlemanly pose, or in some cases because of it, a general tone of anxiousness runs through these notes that bear on officialdom. The notes thus evoke in a very plausible manner the insecurities and the frustrations of office-holding in Sung dynasty China. It hardly needs to be emphasized that this is not the impression of Sung bureaucracy that is evoked by formal memorials or official histories. Su Shih, in particular, comes across as a man who feels himself beset on all sides by political foes and incompetents. "Here, gossip and accusations are everywhere." "When a member of our group undertakes something, he must go about it with all possible care and thoroughness if he is to succeed. If the smallest detail is left unattended to, our critics will be unrelenting."¹⁷ Some of Su's notes close with the injunction that the communication must not be shown to anyone else, or even that the recipient must destroy it.¹⁸ When we recall the turmoil of Su Shih's career in office—the struggles over the New

¹⁶ See Su Ch'e 蘇轍, "Wang hsiung Tzu-chan Tuan-ming mu-chih-ming," *Luan-ch'eng chi* 欒城集 (Shanghai: Ku-chi ch'u-pan she, 1987), "hou-chi" 22.1416, and Chou Hui 周輝 (b. 1126), *Ch'ing-po pieh chih* 清波別志 (*Ts'ung-shu chi-ch'eng* ed.), A.127.

¹⁷ See the note translated on pp. 583–84 below.

¹⁸ See, for example, "Yü Li Kung-tse," no. 11, and "Yü Ts'ao Tzu-fang," no. 3, *Wen-chi* 51.1500 and 58.1775.

Policies, Su's imprisonment on charges of treason, the factional discord of the Yuan-yu era—it is hardly surprising that he should feel this way.

The second type of note is that which deals primarily with personal matters, such as food and health, housing and finances, problems with relatives, etc. A sampling of these notes follows:

(To Tu Meng-chien, from Huang-chou:) The bamboo shoots that Governor Chu has sent are said to come from T'an-chou. Could they be what is known as young "cats heads"? If I keep them, the Buddhist cooks here are bound to ruin them. I am giving them all to you. When you make a dish out of them, please just send me a plateful. (58.1758, no. 3)

Chu Shou-ch'ang was governor of nearby Cheng-chou (Wu-han). The letter must date from Su's first months in Huang-chou, when he stayed in the Ting-hui Monastery there.

(To Wu Tzu-yeh, from Huang-chou:) The various kinds of Fu-chien tea you so kindly sent are all of the highest quality. Where you are it is hard even to get tea for oneself, and now you have sent me some as a gift. I am ashamed, truly ashamed! The shark and red carp are also great delicacies. I cannot adequately express my gratitude. As for the "strengthening ointment," I am not sure exactly what it is. I will store it safely away, but I do not know how to use it. Please instruct me in detail the next time you write. . . . (57.1735, no. 3)

Wu Tzu-yeh (Fu-ku) sent these gifts from his native Ch'ao-chou (Kwangtung).¹⁹

(To P'u Ch'uan-cheng, from Huang-chou:) Nephew Ch'ien-sheng told me several times that his uncle gives no thought to livelihood and instead buys up large numbers of paintings, calligraphy, and curios, frequently even pawning things for money to buy more. He asked me to try to persuade you to stop. I agree with Ch'ien-sheng completely. You cannot continue this way, giving no thought to how you will support yourself in retirement. After you resign you certainly cannot just eat and dress crudely, and close your door to all callers. And if needy friends or relatives ask for your help, you cannot just turn them away. How could you not prepare in advance for these obligations? You cannot simply say "I have a good son, and I plan my livelihood with him." In recent years I myself have come to consider paintings, calligraphy, and curios to be as worthless as dung. Even if you don't agree with me, you should give some thought to what I have said here out of respect for my late nephew. (60.1819)

The addressee must be a brother-in-law of Su Shih's cousin, Su Pu-ch'i (Tzu-cheng), who was married to a woman with the surname P'u. Su's nephew, Ch'ien-sheng, was one of this woman's sons.

¹⁹ See "Yü Li Kung-tse," no. 12, *Wen-chi* 51.1500, in which Su asks another friend for help identifying the ointment and its use.

(To Wang Ting-kuo, after leaving Huang-chou:) I report: Today Ching-fan arrived at Ssu-chou and passed on to me your gracious letter of the twenty-third day of the tenth month, together with your six new poems and the one outstanding song, all of which comforted me greatly. The river is frozen and the boats stuck fast, so that even a short distance between us seems a thousand miles. I am sure you understand how morose I have been feeling. But once I received your wonderful writings, I felt happy all day long, my gloom dissipating like ice breaking up. How fortunate I am!

When I was on my way to Yang-chou, I submitted a document requesting permission to live in Ch'ang-chou. Then I received word that the officials in charge of memorials held onto my document and were unwilling to submit it to the throne. Now I have written a separate petition and am sending a messenger to take it personally to the capital to submit it.

Recently I purchased a small farm in Yi-hsing, Ch'ang-chou. It produces over a hundred piculs of grain annually, which should be enough to support my family. It is not that I do not appreciate the attractions of Yang-chou. But when a desperate gibbon flees into the forest, it does not have time to choose its tree.

Master Huang is sending a man to the southern capital, and so I am writing this in a hurry. To thank you, I have matched the rhymes of one of your poems, but have no time to do any more. The new canal is very shallow and is also frozen and impassable. I will set out as soon as the water is deep enough, but I may have to wait until the first of the year. I wonder if you will still be in Sung when I arrive? If my request is granted, I may attach my boat behind Hsuan-hsien's and come south with him. Otherwise, I will go upstream to the western capital, then proceed overland to Ju-chou. However, I must bury a wet nurse before I start, and when I arrive at the southern capital I shall have to remain there one month. It is nighttime now and I am so tired I cannot tell you everything that is on my mind. By all means take care of yourself. (52.1522, no. 16)

When he left Huang-chou, Su was first reassigned as governor of Ju-chou, just south of the western capital (Lo-yang). This letter was written in Ssu-chou, north of Yang-chou, while Su was en route to Ju-chou but still trying to get his appointment annulled. Sung is another name for the southern capital. Su Shih's request to move to his recently purchased farm in Ch'ang-chou was eventually granted, but within two months he was reassigned to Teng-chou (in modern Shantung).

(To Yang Chün-su, returning to Court from Teng-chou:) It has been twenty-one years since I left our hometown. Nearly all the venerable elders in our village have withered away. You alone are as ageless as the tortoise and crane, and grow ever more luxuriant like the pine and cypress. It is a great blessing. I lack anything appropriate with which to show my affection and can only send this one copper foot-warmer. If you fill it with hot water at night, stop its mouth tightly, and wrap cloth around it, it will remain warm until the next morning. I am certain that with your Way and *ch'i* you do not need to use this, but I send it now simply to convey my humble devotion. My best wishes to your son, degree candidate thirty-seven, and to nephew eleven. (56.1668, no. 3)

Su's uncle, Huan, had married a woman with the surname Yang. The addressee is probably her brother or some other member of her family.²⁰

(To Tzu-an, returning to Court from Teng-chou:) Tzu-yu has been appointed policy critic, and I expect that he too will arrive in the capital before long. As for the pines that are being cut down on our eastern plot of graves, we must trouble you to pay close attention. If any more are cut down, you and brother Yang Five must go to inspect. A careful count should be taken of the trees and communicated to the tenant farmer to prevent such easy theft. Otherwise, you might post a notice announcing a reward to get people to turn the thieves in. That should also work. We trust the matter entirely to your judgment. The half-pound of Ah Gelatin was really boiled from the waters of the well at Ah.²¹ The five pounds of Ch'ing-chou dates are just a token I am offering to you. If I can do anything in the capital for you, please let me know. (60.1830, no. 3)

Tzu-yu is Su Shih's younger brother (Su Ch'e), and Tzu-an is Su Shih's cousin (Su Pu-wei), who had remained in Su's hometown in Mei-shan.

(To Tseng Tzu-hsuan, while in the Han-lin Academy:) I report: You condescended to instruct me, and it is a great comfort for me to hear that you are enjoying a myriad blessings. As for the pagoda inscription, I would not presume to be negligent. I have spent the past several days at my government office, where affairs are as tangled as a ball of hemp. When I come home I still have official documents to attend to, and often I do not rest until midnight. At the fifth watch I must rise again. I really have had no energy left to write your inscription. Let me ask for one more month. If I am untrue to this promise, may the Yellow River do with me as it will! I hope you will be able to smile at this and forgive me. Some day soon we should plan to meet at least briefly together. (50.1469, no. 7)

The addressee is Tseng Pu, the controversial advocate of the New Policies. Tseng was out of power when this was written, serving as a prefectural governor.

(To P'an Yen-ming, from Hang-chou:) The brides of my two sons have made several items of clothing to be burned for our late elderly wet nurse, née Jen. I presume to trouble you, sir, to have a servant purchase several bundles of paper money and spread a large amount of kindling in front of her grave. Give one

²⁰ This note, as well as the two immediately preceding it in K'ung's edition, make it clear that Yang Chün-su was a relative, and that Su had not seen him since leaving his hometown. (Cf. "Yü Yang mou," *Wen-chi* "Yi-wen hui-pien," 2.2450, also said to be addressed to a Mei-shan Yang.) This must then be a different Yang Chün-su than the man of the same name who replaced Hsu Ta-shou as governor of Huang-chou in 1083. The date editorially supplied to this note ("returning to Court from Teng-chou") is also problematic, because it had been seventeen years rather than twenty-one since Su last departed from his hometown. Either the dating of the note must be wrong, or the number in the text of the note has been miscopied.

²¹ A well famous for water from which such a medicinal substance could be extracted, located in Ah-hsien, Shantung.

offering of wine and then burn everything, and do not disturb it once the fire starts. We miss her deeply, so please do not take offense. I beg this of you and sob with shame. (53.1585, no. 9)

A wide variety of material goods figures prominently in these personal letters and is one of their most memorable aspects. It is mostly quite humble items (vegetables, ointment, dried fish, a foot-warmer, tea, etc.) that are being sent back and forth. Still, it is evident that the exchange of these things was important, perhaps as important as the notes themselves, in affirming affection and friendship. Collectively, the notes evoke an image of Sung dynasty China being crisscrossed by runners carrying notes and small gifts. Who were these men? References to them in the notes themselves are cursory and vague. They are usually just described as “a man being sent” (*ch'ien-jen* 遣人) or a “special messenger” (*chuan-jen* 專人). It is hard to know for certain whether such couriers were private servants or low-ranking members of the author's administrative staff. Often, they must have been the former, since the activity of note-sending continues even when the sender is out of office and has no staff. Occasionally a writer may send his letter along with another man's messenger (as Su Shih did with his note to Wang Ting-kuo), showing that the logistics of delivery were apt to be a problem. Nevertheless, many if not most of the notes seem to have been carried by personal envoys; that is, they were sent through private channels rather than through the government post system.

Two of the notes translated above pertain to family problems. In one an in-law is admonished for spending money on paintings and calligraphy rather than setting it aside for his retirement. Su Shih invokes the name of one of the man's sons, who seems to have recently died, to lend weight to his argument. In the other note Su Shih brings up the problem of trees being stolen from the site of his ancestral graves. Pines were of course regularly planted around tombs as a hopeful symbol of the eternal even in the place of death. But to non-family members the value of the timber could be an irresistible temptation, and it sounds as if the Su clan may indeed have to post reward notices to curtail the pilfering. It has often been remarked that Sung literati were surprisingly unattached to their native place. It was not unusual for a man to stay away from his ancestral home and the all-important graves for decades at a time,

or even to end up settling down in retirement in another part of the empire. Su Shih is an example of this. After his two trips home early in his career (the late 1050s and the late 1060s) to mourn for his parents, Su Shih never again returned to his native place. In his later years, when he made plans for his retirement, it is clear that Su hoped to settle somewhere in the southeast rather than return to Mei-shan. Notes like these two, which date from the later years, remind us that while Su may have kept physically distant from his ancestral home and clan, they were not forgotten. One can see that family matters and problems lay in the back of his mind, and that from hundreds of miles away he would dash off a note, now and then, intended to resolve some new domestic crisis of which he had received word. It is not hard to detect some guilt mixed in with the exasperation and sense of helplessness contained in these letters home.

The letter to Tseng Pu above brings up another matter that must have been a constant aggravation in Su Shih's life. Given his fame as a man of letters, friends and even non-acquaintances pestered Su continuously to write things for them. It appears that Tseng Pu had asked Su to compose a literary inscription for some Buddhist shrine or pagoda. Typically, such a piece of writing, which would tell the story of the pagoda, would be inscribed on stone and displayed at the site. Su Shih refers to Tseng's request in no fewer than six notes to him (in all, thirteen notes to Tseng survive), promising always to get to the inscription soon. These notes are spread over a three or four year period. In the very last of them, written as Su Shih is exiled south in 1097, Su says that he has finally completed a rough draft of the piece but, owing to his political troubles, does not dare to forward it to Tseng. Su's surviving works contain no pagoda inscription, and it would seem that Tseng Pu never received any such piece. We can only speculate as to why Su Shih did not want to write the piece, but it is obvious that he did not want to. Ou-yang Hsiu, Su Shih's mentor, describes in his own notes how his life was plagued by requests to write grave inscriptions.²² Perhaps Ou-yang gave the young Su some advice on this score, for Su Shih adopted a

²² See Ou-yang's notes nos. 13 and 14 to Liu Yuan-fu, *Ou-yang Wen-chung kung chi* 歐陽文忠公集 (Kuo-hsueh chi-pen ts'ung-shu ed.), sect. 17, "Shu-chien" 5.17-18.

strict policy, to which he made just a few exceptions, of not writing funerary literature.²³ However, as we can see from the letters to Tseng Pu, there were other sorts of writing that no literary man could categorically disavow. Su still had to face endless requests and placate those who submitted them as best he could.

Two of the notes above mention wet nurses. In the first instance (in the note to Wang Ting-kuo) it is actually a woman, née Yang, who had been Su Ch'e's wet nurse and then had lived on in Su Ch'e's family. Upon her death Su Ch'e had left her remains in a monastery in Sung-chou, but it was not until years later that the remains were properly buried—the task to which Su Shih refers.²⁴ In the second instance it is the woman, née Jen, who had been Su Shih's own wet nurse and who subsequently looked after Su Shih's three sons, Mai, Tai, and Kuo. The woman had died at the age of seventy-two with Su Shih in Huang-chou. Su Shih's formal eulogy for the woman survives, which is unusual enough, but it is brief and formulaic.²⁵ This note suggests the emotion involved. It was written some ten years after the woman had died. Su's sons together with their new wives and Su himself request an old Huang-chou friend to arrange the grave-side offering. One wonders how often this sort of ritual was performed, or if perhaps the arrangements made on this occasion were meant to mark an anniversary of the woman's death? This is the only mention of such an observance that survives in Su's writings.

Aside from the two general types of notes discussed above, those that pertain to Su Shih's public and to his private life, special mention should be made of the subset of notes written during Su's Ling-nan exile, the last several years of his life. Su's notes are particularly numerous from this period, which includes Su's confinement to Hui-chou (one hundred miles east of Kuang-chou) and to Hai-nan Island. Finding himself far removed from his friends, Su Shih wrote often to reassure them. But there were other causes as well of his prolific note-writing during these years. It so happened that during Su's years in Hui-chou his maternal cousin, Ch'eng Chih-ts'ai (tzu Cheng-fu), was serving as judicial intendant of Kuang-tung

²³ See "Ta Li Fang-shu," no. 8, *Wen-chi* 53.1579.

²⁴ See "Pao-mu Yang-shih mu-chih-ming," *Wen-chi* 15.473.

²⁵ "Ju-mu Jen-shih mu-chih-ming," *Wen-chi* 15.473.

Circuit, which included Su's Hui-chou. Over seventy notes from Su to Ch'eng survive, in which Su broaches a wide range of personal and social concerns.²⁶ The fact that Su Shih was being urged by his brother and others to desist from composing poetry, which had gotten him in so much political trouble, may also be relevant. (Su Ch'e had told him that it was not good enough to keep to himself whatever poems he wrote; he must burn his brush and inkstone.)²⁷ Su Shih's poetic output did decline during these years. Furthermore, over a quarter of the poems he did produce were ostensibly impersonal: those he wrote by "matching the rhymes" of poems by T'ao Ch'ien. Su Shih was less apt than normal during these years to communicate with his friends through poetry, and his output of prose notes increased accordingly.

The modern ethnographer may wish that Su Shih had recorded in greater detail the customs of these marginal regions of Han Chinese culture. However, if our interest is in the circumstances this most eminent Sung scholar faced in distant southern exile, and the concerns that occupied him, then the notes Su wrote in Hui-chou and Hai-nan are a rich and incomparable source. We learn from the notes precisely who accompanied Su into exile: his youngest son, Kuo, his concubine of fifteen years, Chao-yun, and two elderly female cooks.²⁸ The cooks died, presumably of malaria, not long after arriving in Hui-chou, and Chao-yun was to die there too.²⁹ We also learn that at first Su lodged in government quarters in Hui-chou, but he was not allowed to stay there long (presumably because of his status as a "demoted official") and had to build his own house.³⁰ This undertaking consumed nearly all of his ready cash, and soon he decided to sell on the private market a bond that was part of his official salary. Su was prepared to sell the bond at a large discount, so desperate was he for cash, but he had left the document with friends in Kuang-chou and now it could not even be

²⁶ See *chüan* 54 of *Wen-chi*.

²⁷ "Yü Ch'eng Cheng-fu," no. 16, *Wen-chi* 54.1594.

²⁸ "Yü Wang Ting-kuo," no. 40 and "Yü Ch'en Chi-ch'ang," no. 16, *Wen-chi* 52.1531 and 53.1570. The first of these notes refers to three cooks, but that is evidently a textual error (unless Su meant to include Chao-yun among them).

²⁹ "Yü Lin T'ien-ho," no. 15, *Wen-chi* 55.1633; cf. "Ta Liao Ming-lueh," no. 4, *Wen-chi* 53.1558. For Chao-yun's death, see "Chao-yun mu-chih-ming," *Wen-chi* 15.473-74.

³⁰ "Yü Nan-hua Pien-lao," no. 12, *Wen-chi* 61.1875.

located.³¹ When Su was later “sent across the sea” to Hai-nan Island, he had to build another house for himself, and this time he was personally involved in the labor. (“Recently, I have built a thatched house that is a few pillars across. It is barely enough to protect us from the wind and rain, yet the labor and expense were almost more than we could bear. We relied on some ten students who came to help with the work. I myself trod about in the water and mud—the humiliation of it was unspeakable.”)³² In Su Shih’s Hui-chou notes to his cousin, the circuit inspector, we see him address a host of local problems and projects. He discusses the need for new barracks for the local militia, how a bridge might be constructed over a treacherous river crossing, what should be done to rebuild the neighboring town of Po-lo after it was destroyed by fire, and how private contributions might be solicited to construct a pool for “freeing fish” (Buddhist good works). All the while, Su continued to correspond with his friends on personal matters. We read in these notes about the foods they sent, his own struggle with illness, the books he had at his disposal, and the classical commentaries he wrote.

SU SHIH’S OTHER WRITINGS IN LIGHT OF HIS NOTES

Another reading of Su Shih’s notes is also possible. In this case they are not studied for their factual details so much as they are read against Su’s other and better known writings. Here it is attitudes and motives rather than circumstantial particulars that are illuminated. The attitudes revealed may complement, supplement, or even contradict those expressed by Su in the more prestigious forms of writing. In whichever case, the notes remind us of the limitations of all of the written forms. They remind us that each genre, including the note itself, has its weighty conventions of subject and tone. Repeatedly, one finds that Su’s notes reveal dimensions

³¹ See “Yü Wang Min-chung,” nos. 8 and 12, *Wen-chi* 56.1691 and 56.1694, and cf. the comments of Wang Wen-kao 王文詒 (b. 1764), *Su Wen-chung kung shih pien-chu chi-ch’eng tsung-an* 蘇文忠公詩編注集成總案 (Ch’eng-tu: Pa-shu shu-she, 1985 rpt. of 1819 ed.), 40.12a and 41.1b.

³² “Yü Ch’eng hsiu-ts’ai,” no. 1, *Wen-chi* 55.1628.

of his thought and values that are not or could not be expressed in his more formal writings.

Notes that supplement attitudes expressed elsewhere are easily found among the pieces that pertain to statecraft and politics. An important example helps to account for what was perhaps the most startling development in Su's political career—his emergence in the early Yuan-yu period as a supporter of one of the cornerstones of Wang An-shih's New Policies, the hired service system. Throughout the preceding fifteen years, Su Shih had been a vocal opponent of the New Policies, memorializing endlessly against them first as a Court official and later as a prefectural governor. Eventually, the ministers who were implementing the reforms decided to make an example of this troublesome critic and had him arrested and formally charged with having slandered the Court and emperor. But when Su Shih reappeared in public life, after the five-year exile that resulted from his trial, we find him arguing strenuously with Ssu-ma Kuang and other anti-reformers, who were then moving to dismantle Wang's New Policies. Su now advocated retaining the hired service system (Wang's alternative to the use of a rotating draft to supply menial personnel to local government offices), and he was virtually as outspoken and persistent in his disagreement with the newly ascendant anti-reformers as he had been years before in his battle with the reformers. Unable to dissuade Ssu-ma Kuang from abandoning the hired service system, Su Shih eventually requested that he be removed from the capital and reassigned to the provinces, much as he had done when the New Policies were first implemented over his objections in the early 1070s.

It is hard to know what to make of this turnabout. If we are predisposed to view Su's actions sympathetically, we might speculate that during the intervening years Su must have been persuaded that this particular reform was a good one and consequently have changed his stance. But nowhere does Su say precisely this in the various memorials he wrote arguing for retention of the reform. He confines his comments to what he now considers to be the benefits of the hired service system and does not address the matter of his own history of opposition. We may well be left with nagging doubts about his change of heart. Could it be that Su's politics were entirely fickle, and that there is no sense, no logic, to be found in

this turnaround? Or, even worse, could we be witnessing some streak of perversity in Su Shih that made him dissent vociferously with the party in power, whichever it was? Su Shih has alternately been accused, in his own as in modern times, of being both stubborn and inconsistent.³³ Perhaps this episode exemplifies these traits that his critics have found in him.

It is the survival of certain of Su Shih's notes that largely lay these doubts to rest, showing Su Shih came consciously to regret his earlier categorical opposition to Wang's reforms. The most telling note is a brief one Su wrote to his good friend, T'eng Ta-tao (Yuan-fa), apparently when T'eng was setting off for the capital during the period of political transition that followed the death of Emperor Shen-tsung in 1085. The crucial passage is the opening paragraph:

What I had hoped to say to you face-to-face was this: At the start of the New Policies era, we and our faction all had a biased view of things and that is what caused us to dissent. Although our hearts were steadfast and never swerved from loyal concern for our nation, our words were in error and little of what we said accorded with reason. Today sagely virtue is daily renewed and a grand transformation is occurring in all quarters. When I look back upon our former course I see all the more how misguided it was. As for changing one's principles to gain advancement, I would never dare to suggest you do that. But if we continue our carping criticism, the distress and problems we will cause will be even more harmful than before. . . .³⁴

We see from this the seriousness of Su's reconsideration of his earlier actions.³⁵ Subsequently, once Su was recalled to the capital

³³ Early in the Yuan-yü era the censor Sun Sheng observed that Su Shih was so headstrong and unreasonable that if he were entrusted with power he would do as much harm as Wang An-shih had done, and in the Southern Sung Chu Hsi said much the same thing. See *Hsu tzu-chih t'ung-chien ch'ang-pien* 續資治通鑑長編 (1881 ed.), 388.12b-13a, and *Chu-tzu yü-lei* 朱子語類 (Peking: Chung-hua shu-chü, 1986), 13.3109-10, 3112. Recently, Lo Ssu-ting 羅思鼎 sharply criticized what he sees as inconsistencies in Su Shih's earlier politics, and denounced Su as a turncoat and opportunist. See "Ts'ung Wang An-shih pien-fa k'an Ju-Fa lun-chan ti yen-pien" 從王安石變法看儒法論戰的演變, *Hung-ch'i* 1974.2:26.

³⁴ "Yü T'eng Ta-tao," no. 8, *Wen-chi* 51.1478. For the date of this note I am following Wang Shui-chao 王水照, "Kuan-yü Su Shih 'Yü T'eng Ta-tao shu' ti hsi-nien ho chu-chih wen-t'i" 關於蘇軾《與滕達道書》的系年和主旨問題, *Wen-hsueh p'ing-lun* 1981.1, pp. 59-61. Wang (p. 59) calls attention to similar sentiments in another of Su's notes to T'eng, *Wen-chi* 51.1491, no. 48.

³⁵ In recent years this note has sparked its own controversy. One Su Shih scholar, who is committed to the idea that Su's politics were consistent and unchanging throughout his career, insists that this note is not an admission of past mistakes and is simply a warning to T'eng not to jeopardize his career by clinging inflexibly to anti-reformist values. See Tseng

and found himself at odds with those who would repeal every last reform, he wrote in a note to another friend: "In years past all men of learning took Ching (Wang An-shih) as their sole leader. Nowadays, all men of learning follow no one but Wen (Ssu-ma Kuang). The person they follow has changed, but the way they follow him is the same."³⁶ Such remarks provide glimpses of what in Su's mind were the larger principles behind his disagreement with Ssu-ma Kuang in the Yuan-yu era.

Su Shih's governorship of Hang-chou followed immediately upon this disagreement, and in this next episode in Su's career we likewise find that his notes help to answer questions that have been raised about his behavior and motives. Su Shih remained in Hang-chou for just two years. In later centuries Su's governorship would be remembered primarily for the "saving" of West Lake, which was accomplished by clearing it of weeds and better regulating its feeder streams. (Su also built a dike that transverses the lake to this day, and bears his name.) At the time, however, Su devoted most of his energy to a far more serious problem—widespread rice shortages and the threat of famine. Su's lake project pales in comparison to his efforts to avert starvation.

The story of Su's campaign to avoid famine is preserved today in the string of memorials he submitted during these two years, in which he alternately pleads, demands, and admonishes the Court to give relief to a beleaguered Hang-chou. (The memorials fill over fifty pages in the modern typeset text of Su's works.)³⁷ In the spring of the first year (1089) there had been extensive flooding across the Hang-chou and neighboring prefectures, which delayed the planting of rice and made the harvest poor. In the autumn of the following year, when the grain reserves were already dangerously low, severe storms damaged the crop in the fields. Refugees flocked to the cities, fleeing from districts that had no reserves left, there were

Tsao-chuang, *Su Shih p'ing-chuan* 蘇軾評傳 (Ch'eng-tu: Ssu-ch'uan jen-min ch'u-pan-she, 1984), pp. 315–27, and "Lun Su Shih cheng-chih chu-chang ti yi-chih hsing" 論蘇軾政治主張的一致性, *Wen-hsueh p'ing-lun ts'ung-k'an* 3 (1979): 233–51. This reading of the note seems strained and has been disputed by other scholars. See Wang Shui-chao, "Kuan-yü Su Shih 'Yü T'eng Ta-tao shu,'" pp. 58–62, and Chu Ching-hua 朱靖華, *Su Shih hsin-lun* 蘇軾新論 (Chi-nan: Ch'i-lu shu-she, 1983), pp. 34–35.

³⁶ "Yü Yang Yuan-su," no. 17, *Wen-chi* 55.1655.

³⁷ See *Wen-chi* 30.849–33.937, where some memorials on other topics are also presented.

food riots outside the government granaries, and the price of rice on the private market soared. Su Shih proposed a variety of measures to cope with the shortages, which included reducing the quotas of grain that the region was required to ship to the capital, increasing local government revenues, so that authorities could buy rice to restock the granaries (the revenue would come from the sale of Buddhist ordination certificates issued to the region by the central government), and waiving transport taxes in nearby prefectures, to encourage private merchants to bring their surplus grain to Hang-chou for sale. Each of Su's proposals was eventually adopted, though never on the scale Su first requested. Furthermore, Su found that he had to argue long and hard for each proposal before he prevailed. It is clear that Su had to struggle not only against the Court's bureaucratic lethargy, its natural reluctance to allocate special expenditures or to remit taxes, and its remove from problems in the provinces, but also against his own immediate superiors, the circuit intendants of the Liang-che region. It turns out that throughout the period several of the circuit intendants kept minimizing the seriousness of the situation in their reports to the throne, or even claiming that there was no shortage of rice. If one follows Su's references, in his own counter-memorials, to these reports, one can see his initial patience with what he took to be simple ignorance give way to exasperation and eventually to rancor, as he becomes convinced that his superiors are willfully concealing the truth in order first to tell the Court what it wants to hear and later to avoid reprimand for mismanagement.

Su Shih was recalled to the capital in the spring of 1091. After he arrived back at the Court, as Han-lin Academician, he continued to memorialize about the need for further famine relief. Two days after his last memorial, a pair of Su's long-standing political enemies, the censors Chia Yi and Yang Wei, challenged Su's reports and called for an investigation into their veracity. The people of the Che region, Chia Yi asserts, are habitually untruthful and are apt to exaggerate minor difficulties. Moreover, Chia Yi goes on, "I fear that their commissioners seek to achieve notoriety and have, of their own accord, inflated the number of refugees, hoping in this way to win promotion for themselves."³⁸ Chia Yi means that by over-

³⁸ *Hsu tzu-chih t'ung-chien ch'ang-pien* 462.2b. Yang Wei's memorial follows on p. 3a-b.

stating the seriousness of the problem, the local authorities (that is, Su Shih) intended to call attention to themselves and later to take credit for implementing policies that avoided a great disaster, when in fact there was no threat of one.

These charges of misrepresentation came to nothing. Fan Tsu-yü, a longtime friend of Su Shih who was then serving as a policy advisor, wrote a lengthy defense on Su's behalf in which he refuted point by point the doubts raised by the censors,³⁹ and soon the investigation was dropped. Fan appealed to Confucian principles of government, arguing that the Court should only worry that it may not be doing enough to help a province that is faced with famine, rather than to doubt the veracity of its claims. He also pointed out that it was inherently unlikely that provincial officials would misrepresent this sort of problem, since any such untruth could so easily be exposed, and he cited reports of the shortages from officials other than Su Shih. This is all persuasive enough, but the fact remains that Su Shih's lengthy and numerous memorials are the main source, especially for us today, of information about this crisis in Hang-chou. What if he did exaggerate the seriousness of the problems? How could we ever know?

Notes such as the one I translate below do not entirely resolve this historiographical problem, for they too come from Su Shih, but they do diminish its urgency. This particular note was written in the autumn of 1090, after the storms of the seventh month had dimmed hopes for a decent harvest. It was sent to Ch'ien Ssu (Mu-fu), the governor of Yueh-chou, a prefecture adjoining Hang-chou to the southeast. The man referred to as Chung-yü is Ma Sheng, who was the judicial intendant of the Che-tung and Che-hsi circuits, and thus one of Su's (and Ch'ien's) immediate superiors and one who was responsible for overseeing the agricultural as well as the judicial administration in the region.⁴⁰

(To Ch'ien Mu-fu, from Hang-chou:) Today I received the official proclamation cautioning us that the Min bandits may in time reach Ch'ü and Mu, but I believe the danger is not imminent. However, the several prefectures in Che-tung have experienced severe flooding, and from the twenty-first to the twenty-third of the

³⁹ *Fan T'ai-shih chi* 范太史集 (*Ssu-k'u ch'üan-shu* ed.), 20.9a-16b.

⁴⁰ For Ma Sheng, see K'ung Fan-li's commentary on Su Shih's note, "Yü Ma Chung-yü," *Wen-chi* "Yi-wen hui-pien" 3.2485.

seventh month there was heavy rain and violent wind, which nearly ruined all the crops. The disaster is no less than last year's, but this time the reserves in the Ever Normal Granary have already been depleted. Responsibility for dealing with this crisis rests entirely with Chung-yü and me. I need to discuss the matter in person with him and cannot deal with it fully in letters. I have asked him to come here repeatedly for this purpose, but he has not paid any attention to me. Winter has just begun and although Tzu-kung will arrive in Che-hsi any day,⁴¹ we can only achieve success with matters as weighty as these if all of us reach a consensus together. The burden of his trip here, past the few post-stations,⁴² would be no more than when he comes to observe the tidal bore, which itself is pleasant enough. Try to persuade Chung-yü with this argument, but do not say I told you so. Would you? Would you? When a member of our group undertakes something, he must go about it with all possible care and thoroughness if he is to succeed. If the smallest detail is left unattended to, our critics will be unrelenting. Right now the price of rice is stable, but one month from now it will rise again. Day and night I wait for Chung-yü to come. If I set loose my subordinates to buy up one hundred thousand piculs of rice, and then if the fiscal intendants vie to purchase more for the army's rations and our contribution to the central government, the price of rice will jump dramatically. It may not be easy to discuss one by one all the other measures that should now be taken. I hope that you will think this over and speak out on whatever matters you feel you can address. Thank you! Thank you! I myself have already memorialized twice on this matter. Although the various ministers may not be pleased, there is no choice but to take action. (51.1505, no. 11)

Su Shih is trying to get his colleague and peer, Ch'ien Ssu, to persuade their superior to visit Hang-chou, so that Su can present his case about the crisis there in person, and so that Ma Sheng will see the situation first-hand. At this point Su Shih is still hopeful of enlisting the support of this particular circuit intendant, but he is worried that the man seems to be ignoring his pleas. Just at this time, Su was asking the Court to diminish Che-hsi's annual quota of rice to be supplied to the central government by one-half.⁴³ This would maximize local supplies, keeping the price down, and, in addition, make it possible for Su to buy rice to restock the Ever Normal Granaries (the one hundred thousand piculs referred to in the

⁴¹ Tzu-kung is Fan Pai-lu, who had been appointed Han-lin Academician earlier in the year and was presumably sent as a special commissioner to the Che-hsi region that fall, though his biography (a grave inscription in *Fan T'ai-shih chi* 44.12a) records no such commission.

⁴² For this use of the phrase *shu she* 數舍, see Su's "Yü Chih-weng," *Wen-chi*, "Yi-wen hui-pien," 3.2497.

⁴³ See "Hsiang-tu chun-pei chen-chi ti yi chuang," *Wen-chi* 31.892-94, a memorial written in the ninth month of 1090.

note). The policy suggestions that fill Su's memorials are precisely those alluded to in this note.

If Su Shih were engaged in an elaborate deception about the situation in Hang-chou, it is hardly likely that he would be trying, through private communications, to arrange for his superior to visit him there. Everything about a note such as this, and especially its tone, supports the case for Su's sincerity in this episode. It is a kind of support, moreover, that no document addressed to the Court could ever provide.

Read against Su Shih's literary works, the notes may likewise affect our impressions of the great poet. First, the notes have a degree of literary merit all by themselves. Chiao Hung, as mentioned above, considered them one of Su's two literary "marvels." It is the quick elegance of these short missives that is appreciated in such an evaluation, their spontaneity and light grace. Northern Sung scholars had developed just such an aesthetic in the related field of calligraphy: they commented on the superiority of the surviving fragments of short personal messages, dashed off spontaneously by the ancient masters, over the more formal and lengthy calligraphic inscriptions by the same men.⁴⁴ The Sung scholars' own notes came to be similarly valued, and eventually they were prized as much for their distinctive literary style as for their calligraphy.

It must be allowed that the identity of their author contributes substantially to what is perceived as the literary interest of Su Shih's notes. We are ever aware, as we read these short pieces, that they come from Su Shih's hand. We are intrigued to watch as the renowned man of letters turns his attention to everyday affairs. To catch a glimpse of great persons dealing with humble matters—surely there is a fascination here that is universal. Nor is it easy, or even necessary, to distinguish between biographical revelation and literary appeal. Consider the note to Yang Chün-su, an in-law, which accompanied Su's gift of a foot-warmer. It is not only the fact that Su would send such a present that interests us, it is also the tone of his accompanying note, which virtually transforms the humble gift

⁴⁴ See Ou-yang Hsiu's remarks on a note attributed to Wang Hsien-chih, "Chin Wang Hsien-chih fa-t'ieh," *Ou-yang wen-chung kung chi*, section 15, "Chi-ku lu," 4.127.

into a symbol of Su's affection for his elderly relative and even his distant homeland. Still, it is precisely because the note, with its concise but decorous expression of emotion for this obscure old man, comes from Su Shih that it is memorable. If the note had been written by an equally obscure person it would not have survived, much less hold interest for readers today.

A few of Su Shih's notes actually approximate poems in their simple lyricism. An example follows:

(To Mao Wei-chan:) The year is nearly over and outside the wind and rain blow cold. Inside my paper windows and bamboo room the flame of the lamp burns with a greenish glow. Now and then I find a subtle but exquisite flavor in these surroundings. I have no way to send it to you but would be ashamed to enjoy it all by myself. I imagine this will bring a smile to your face. (59.1798)⁴⁵

It is helpful to recall, when encountering such a note, that Su Shih was fond of literary experimentation. Specifically, he liked to take the aesthetics of *shih* 詩 poetry and extend them to other forms. He did this with the song (*tz'u*), with the prose rhapsody (*wen-fu* 文賦), and with short prose pieces (later called *hsiao p'in wen*). This note marks a similar attempt. It could hardly be more like a poem. But is there anything such a note expresses that might not be expressed in a poem? In this instance Su may have felt that the note was better suited to capture the complex feeling not of the "flavor" itself (for what could do that better than a *shih* poem?) but of wanting to send it. We have seen how often the function of a note was to accompany and present a material gift. Here of course the note itself embodies the present. Su fully expects, moreover, that his friend will be amused by the contradictions in what he is attempting—sending something that cannot be sent, giving a gift that is immaterial.

It is more common, however, for the "flavor" of Su's notes to remain further apart from those that we associate with his poetry. It was mentioned above that the notes Su wrote that touch on bureaucratic matters are characterized, generally, by a tone of anxiousness. A similar trace of worry, uncertainty, or a harried manner carries over into many of his notes on purely private matters. Partly, the tone is attributable to the nature of the form. Su Shih uses it, often, to ask a favor or politely to urge some course of action. Time,

⁴⁵ The date of this note is uncertain. It is assigned to the few months Su spent in Hu-chou before his arrest in 1079, but this cannot be correct since Su did not spend the winter there.

moreover, seems often to be short: the business at hand is pressing, or the messenger is about to exit the door and will not wait for a lengthier document. Su frequently complains that he cannot deal fully with the matter except in a face-to-face meeting, or that he simply cannot relate recent events, or the emotions they inspire, with words.

It is not just that the note form engenders this tone or that Su Shih merely uses a harried manner to lend force to his requests or to mask the shallowness of his concern. He may do those things, but surely other factors are also involved. Exigencies of daily life are very evident in these notes. Su allows them to show themselves in ways that are rare in his poetry. It is the presence of these pressing matters that is largely responsible for the earnest or even anxious voice. This is understandable enough, but how different that voice can be from that we normally associate with Su Shih: the magisterial poet, the wit, the irrepressibly sanguine philosopher.

Some of the notes have an almost frenetic quality—Su jumping quickly from one topic to another, with no apparent plan other than to say a few words on each. In the most memorable examples, however, Su retains a sense of himself and of higher values, even as he tries to deal with everyday affairs. It is this mixing of the genuinely mundane with a superior vision (however subtly evoked), or of meaningful words with an obligatory politeness that is distinctive. One final example follows:

(To P'an Yen-ming, after departing from Huang-chou:) Since we parted my heart has constantly been filled with longing for you. From far away I hope that you enjoy good health and comfort, and that your loved ones are also fine. I have not seen the yellow proclamation of successful examinees and do not dare to speed my congratulations to you, but I imagine that you must have won a great victory. I have already sent you two letters. Did you receive them? Often I dream of our talk and laughter at East Slope, and when I awake I feel completely at a loss. I have purchased a small farm in Yi-hsing and am requesting permission to live there. I will just be a Ch'ang-chou man! You must have already set off for the departmental examinations.⁴⁶ I have foolishly sent this note anyway, but will not ramble on any further. By all means take care of yourself.

For the literary historian perhaps the most important function of Su Shih's notes is that they cast light as if from a new angle on his

⁴⁶ Administered in the capital. The first examinations Su refers to must be the provincial or qualifying exams.

greatest legacy, his poetry. Occasionally, a note may reveal some fact of Su's life that allows us better to understand a poem. But collectively the notes serve a larger purpose by helping to establish a context in which to read the poetry. It is precisely this sort of context, based on knowledge about daily life and its exigencies, that we lack for the great poets of earlier dynasties, because they left no such body of informal prose. With Su Shih and other Sung poets, the challenge is to discover ways to use this new source.

Certainly, the notes serve to remind us that the world of Su Shih's poetry, for all its richness and beauty, is a sharply delimited one. There is a tendency to think of Chinese poetry, especially that from the Sung, as being supremely personal, spontaneous, and conversant with everyday life. Consequently, we are apt to think that this poetry must embody the unmitigated thoughts and feelings of the poet, or at least be as close to such thoughts as we could ever hope to get. Su's notes should make us wary of this assumption. It is not that the world of Su's notes is utterly different from that of his poetry, but there are discernible differences. The subjects in the notes, or the ways they are broached, provide material with which Su's poetic voice may be compared. When Su first arrives in his Huang-chou exile, for example, he frequently refers in poems to being impoverished. It is hard to know how to take this since Chinese poets, especially those in exile, complain so regularly about being poor. We feel differently about the seriousness of Su's situation, however, when we read in his missives that as eager as he is to see his brother and his own family again (Su Ch'e was to bring them to Huang-chou three months after Su Shih got there), he also dreads their arrival, fearing he will not have the means to support them.⁴⁷ Then there are the notes that capture aspects of Su's life that are unexampled in his poetry: worrying about the theft of pines from his ancestral grave, or arranging a sacrificial offering for a wet nurse dead some ten years. The notes remind us that there were topics in Su's life on which his feelings ran deep that he simply did not write about in poetry. This knowledge ought to enhance our ability to describe what it is that his poetry accomplishes.

⁴⁷ See Su's notes "Yü Wang Ting-kuo," no. 5 and "Yü Chang Tzu-hou," no. 2, as well as the letter, "Yü Chang Tzu-hou ts'an-cheng shu," no. 1, *Wen-chi* 52.1515, 55.1640, and 49.1412.